



found out she was unlikely to play the Asia Cup, she sat me down and told me — ‘Your time is coming and you can’t do anything about it.’ She told me to play with a free mind and not to take pressure. I train now with that mindset. Even if I feel pressure when I go there [Asia Cup], I’ll just call her for advice,” the 24-year-old from Manipur’s Thoubal told *Sportstar*.

Many think it’s a fight for the spot in the team between the 35-year-old Savita and Bichu. But according to the latter, it’s nothing but love and a sense of sisterhood.

“Whatever I say about her will not be enough. If I concede a goal or get demoralised after a bad performance, Savita *di* has the



Being from Manipur, a young Bichu naturally fell in love with football. But due to a twist of fate, she gradually grew an affinity for hockey.



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experience to guide me through all scenarios because she has gone through them herself. Even when Rajani [Etimarpu] *di* was there, both of the seniors have helped me through my bad times.”

While Bichu may feel the heat when she plays in the Asia Cup, where a World Cup spot is at stake, Paramjit Singh — her coach at the Madhya Pradesh Hockey Academy — feels that giving the youngster responsibility will only improve her performance.

“When she’s given the responsibility of being the main goalkeeper, she thrives. She has assisted Savita in the past and played under her. Bichu now has the experience. If she goes to the Asia Cup as the main goalie, her confidence will go up a notch,” the 62-year-old said.

Bichu might be a livewire now on the hockey turf, but picking up the stick was never part of her plans.

An Olympian’s eye

In Manipur, football is part of the state’s fabric. Naturally, a young Bichu fell in love with kicking the ball around.

“I have always loved playing football and used to play with the boys. I had short hair then and people couldn’t tell whether I was a girl, so I blended right in. The boys would discourage me from playing, saying, ‘You’re a girl, you’ll get hurt,’ but I didn’t pay heed. So I continued playing.”

In 2012, she went to give trials at the SAI centre in Imphal for the football team. Unfortunately, she was late and all the spots had been filled. Her father, Romen Singh, pleaded

with the SAI director, who happened to be from the same village. As a solution, the director suggested hockey to Bichu.

“Hockey players were very few at SAI, and in Manipur. The director said I should give trials for hockey, stay at SAI for a few months, and then shift to football if a vacancy opened up. I didn’t have any idea about hockey. I didn’t even know how to hold the stick, but I passed all the physical tests and got into the team,” Bichu recalled.

However, she continued playing football. “I wouldn’t even look in the direction of hockey,” she remembered. “After a couple of months, my father came to speak to the director regarding shifting back to football, but he refused. My name was nationally registered as a hockey player and the director said I couldn’t play football. I cried a lot.”

Romen then asked his daughter to give hockey a shot. Age was on her side, he argued. If she still didn’t like it, he would help her return to football or take up any other sport she preferred.

Gradually, she grew an affinity for hockey. A striker in those days (in football too she was a forward), Bichu loved to leap about and hit the ball goalwards. But there was another twist on the way.

“Manipur’s first Olympian, Nilakomol [Singh] sir, came to SAI to train us for six months. He watched me in training and said, ‘Make her a goalkeeper. Her height and footwork are good; she’ll play for India soon.’”

This began another cycle of Bichu not liking what she was doing, and her father encouraging her to give it a go.